

Installing Claude Code

Companion guide for participants — get set up before our next session

What you'll have at the end

After working through this guide:

- Claude Code installed and authenticated on your machine
- A working `claude` command in your terminal
- A first session running with your project loaded
- Awareness of the most common setup errors and how to fix them

Expect **10–15 minutes** if everything goes smoothly, **30 minutes** if you hit a snag.

Before you start

Requirement	Details
Operating system	macOS 13+ (Ventura), Ubuntu 20.04+ / Debian 10+, or Windows 10 (1809+) with WSL2
RAM	4 GB minimum, 8 GB recommended for larger codebases
Internet	Required — Claude Code talks to Anthropic's cloud API
Anthropic account	Claude Pro, Max, Teams, Enterprise, or API access via Console

You do **not** need a GPU. All AI processing happens on Anthropic's servers; your machine just runs the CLI client.

*The **free Claude.ai plan does not include Claude Code**. You need a paid plan or API credits.*

Pick an installation method

There are two paths. Choose one — don't install both.

Method	Best for	What you get
Native installer (recommended)	Most users	No Node.js needed, auto-updates, one command
npm install	Developers already using Node.js	Familiar workflow, fits Node version managers, easy to pin versions

macOS

Option A — Native installer (recommended)

Open Terminal and run:

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

The installer downloads the binary, puts it on your `PATH`, and sets up auto-updates. Takes under a minute. Close and reopen your terminal afterward so the new `PATH` is picked up.

Option B — Homebrew

If you manage tools through Homebrew:

```
brew install --cask claude-code
```

Homebrew installs don't auto-update. Run `brew upgrade claude-code` manually when you want a new version.

Option C — npm

If you prefer the Node.js ecosystem:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Requires Node.js 18 or later. **Do not** use `sudo`. If you see `EACCES` permission errors, see the troubleshooting section below.

Linux

Option A — Native installer (recommended)

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

Option B — Package managers (apt, dnf, apk)

Anthropic publishes signed `apt`, `dnf`, and `apk` repositories for Linux. Steps vary by distro — check the [official setup docs](#) for the exact commands.

Option C — npm

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Same rules as macOS — Node.js 18+, no `sudo`.

Windows

You have two options. **WSL2 is recommended** — it eliminates most Windows-specific friction.

Option A — WSL2 (recommended)

If you don't have WSL2 installed yet, open **PowerShell as Administrator** and run:

```
wsl --install
```

Restart your computer when prompted. WSL installs Ubuntu by default.

Once you're inside the Ubuntu terminal, follow the **Linux** instructions above. Run all `claude` commands from inside WSL, not from PowerShell or CMD.

Work inside the WSL filesystem (`~/projects/...`), not the mounted Windows drives (`/mnt/c/...`). File operations on `/mnt/c/...` are slower and prone to line-ending issues.

Option B — Native Windows

Claude Code now supports native Windows without WSL. The PowerShell installer command and any prerequisites are in the [official setup docs](#) — check there for the current one-liner since the native Windows path is still rolling out.

Some shell operations run more reliably under WSL. If you hit unexplained issues on native Windows, switch to WSL.

First-time authentication

After installation, just run:

```
claude
```

The first time, Claude Code opens your default browser and asks you to sign in to your Anthropic account. Approve the connection — the CLI receives an authentication token automatically. This works with Pro, Max, Teams, and Enterprise plans.

For headless or CI environments

If there's no browser available (servers, CI pipelines, automation):

```
export ANTHROPIC_API_KEY="sk-ant-..."
```

Add that line to your shell profile (`~/.zshrc` or `~/.bashrc`) so it persists across sessions.

Behind a corporate proxy or firewall?

OAuth redirects often get blocked on corporate networks. Use the `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` method instead. Get a key from platform.claude.com → API Keys.

Verify it's working

```
claude --version
```

You should see a version number printed.

Then run the diagnostic command:

```
claude doctor
```

This checks your environment — auth status, `PATH`, configuration, MCP servers — and reports any issues. Always run it once after install to catch problems early.

Your first session

Open a real project directory and start Claude Code:

```
cd ~/projects/your-app
claude
```

Inside the session, generate a `CLAUDE.md` for the project:

```
> /init
```

Claude scans the project and creates a starter `CLAUDE.md` — your project's persistent context for every future session. Review what it wrote, edit anything wrong, and commit the file to git so your team benefits too.

That's the whole setup. You're done.

Common errors and fixes

Error	Why it happens	Fix
EACCES: permission denied (npm)	npm trying to write to system directories	Set a user-owned npm prefix (see below). Never use sudo.
command not found: claude	The install location isn't on your PATH	Close and reopen your terminal. If still missing, add \$(npm config get prefix)/bin to PATH in your shell profile.
"Claude Code is not supported on Windows"	Running npm from PowerShell or CMD instead of WSL	Run inside the WSL2 (Ubuntu) terminal, not native Windows.
exec: node: not found (WSL)	WSL is finding the Windows Node.js, not a Linux one	Install Node.js inside WSL itself. Verify with which node — should return /usr/bin/node, not /mnt/c/...
Browser OAuth fails on corporate network	Firewall blocks the redirect	Use ANTHROPIC_API_KEY env var instead
Slow file operations	Working on a mounted Windows drive from WSL	Move project to WSL filesystem (~/projects/...)

The one-time npm permission fix

If you hit `EACCES`, do this once and the `sudo` problem goes away forever:

```
mkdir ~/.npm-global
npm config set prefix '~/.npm-global'
echo 'export PATH=~/.npm-global/bin:$PATH' >> ~/.zshrc # or ~/.bashrc on Linux/WSL
source ~/.zshrc
```

Then retry the install. No `sudo` needed.

Cheat sheet

Installing

Command	What it does
<code>curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh bash</code>	Native install — macOS or Linux
<code>brew install --cask claude-code</code>	Homebrew install (macOS)
<code>npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code</code>	npm install (any OS with Node 18+)
<code>wsl --install</code>	Install WSL2 on Windows (PowerShell as Admin)

Verifying

Command	What it does
<code>claude --version</code>	Print installed version
<code>claude doctor</code>	Run setup diagnostics

First-time use

Command	What it does
<code>claude</code>	Start interactive session in the current directory
<code>/init</code> (inside a session)	Generate a starter <code>CLAUDE.md</code> for the project
<code>/auth login</code>	Re-authenticate (if needed)

What to do before our next session

So we don't burn class time on setup:

1. **Install** Claude Code using your preferred method above
2. **Verify** with `claude --version` — confirm it shows a number
3. **Diagnose** with `claude doctor` — fix anything it flags
4. **Sign in** once by running `claude` so OAuth is done
5. (Optional) **Initialize** a real project — `cd` into it, run `claude`, then `/init` to create your first `CLAUDE.md`

If you hit a wall, the common-errors table covers 90% of issues. Bring anything unresolved to the session.

Further reading

- [Claude Code setup guide](#) — the canonical install reference
 - [Claude Code documentation home](#)
 - [Anthropic Console](#) — for API keys and usage monitoring
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